

preciate a certain type of between-the-lines, allegorical, or cryptographic writing which was not uncommon in Italy during the last years of Fascism (cf. the already-mentioned "In Sicily," or some of the allegories in Moravia's collection entitled in Italian "I sogni del pigro," not to mention his novel "The Fancy Dress Party," or the definitely cryptographic "Man Is Strong," by Corrado Alvaro).

What readers outside Italy wanted they found in the only Italian writer who had attained a wide American reputation between Pirandello and the present revival of interest, Ignazio Silone. Italians generally, as is well known, find it hard to grant Silone a high place in the history of their recent literature; his character-drawing seems shallow and *passé*, his writing and his dialogue clumsy, his situations scarcely persuasive however noble the spirit that animates them. Nor did success seem to help him; his first novel, "Fontamara," possessed an intensity and a vernacular forcefulness not to be found in the succeeding and more ambitious ones. Since his return to Italy from exile he has written little; he has been most active as a wise and influential member of one branch of the Socialist Party. "A Handful of Blackberries," his only novel to be published here since "The Seed Beneath the Snow" in 1942, will appear this year.

While Italy did not develop a Fascist literature of apologia and celebration, and on the other hand could not develop one of topical satire and invective as long as the dictatorship lasted, we should recall that during those years most of her writers did manage to maintain what seems an essential premise for the existence of any sort of literary civilization: the sense that literature is one of the arts. By art I suppose we all mean not only something emphatically different from documentary information or propaganda but also something which, as a form of knowledge and a record of experience, is infinitely more relevant, subtle, and mature than those forms of communication; and also, incidentally, more entertaining. There is nothing exceptional about such notions yet I suppose Italian writers have in the ordinary practice of their craft implied them as clearly and naturally as anyone working today.

IN maintaining such artistic concepts of literature, the Italian counterparts of the "little magazines" obviously played their role. In the period following the First World War, besides the already mentioned 900, a considerable importance is attributed to the Roman *La Ronda*, whose function

was a sort of "call to order" in the name of classicism against the noisier and shallower varieties of the *avant garde* on the one side and literary commercialism on the other. Some of the principal exponents of a kind of literature which is most difficult to translate (because it depends on an especially intense and subtle use of linguistic effects) emerged from the Roman circle around that review—Emilio Cecchi, Vincenzo Cardarelli, Antonio Baldini, and the most classical of the recently translated novelists, Riccardo Bacchelli. There was formed, in that and other groups, a kind of *avant garde* which had no longer the aimless bombast of the "futurists" but had, instead, quite subdued and exclusive qualities.

This *avant garde*, especially in its poetic products but also in its prose and criticism, was often accused of ivory-tower preciousness, of lack of real content, of obscurity, of hermeticism. While Fascism lasted some of those accusations were more clearly suspect than they are in other countries, for the critic could conceal within them the recommendation that a specific, propagandistic political coloring be adopted by literature. This did not happen to any important extent, but it is only fair to say that in the peculiar situation of Italy the so-called "difficult" writing did contribute to the preservation of certain standards of artistic integrity at a time when language, style (and style is, in the last analysis, the concrete sign of a

FRASER YOUNG'S LITERARY CRYPT No. 458

A cryptogram is writing in cipher. Every letter is part of a code that remains constant throughout the puzzle. Answer No. 458 will be found in the next issue.

HTMHJX WZXLENXL H

XNPDEQZKHLF MUD KFYFE

RZKQX RHNTL MZLU

UZX XNAFEZDE.

—IDUK G. GDTTZKX.

Answer to Crypt No. 457

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—CONFUCIUS.

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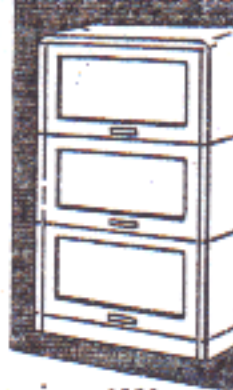
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